

10 OF THE BEST

1. Phanishwar Nath Renu, *Maila Aanchal (1954)*

2. Yashpal, *Jhoota Sach (1960)*

3. Rahi Masoom Raza, *Aadha Gaon (1966)*

4. Shivprasad Singh, *Alag Alag Vaitarni (1967)*

5. Shrilal Shukla, *Raga Darbari (1968)*

6. Vinod Kumar Shukla, *Naukar ki Kameez (1979)*

7. Nirmal Verma, *Raat ka Reporter (1989)*

8. Krishna Sobti, *Dil-o-Danish (1993)*

9. Geetanjali Shree, *Mai (2001)*

10. Shivmurti, *Tarpan (2010)*

ment was scandalised by the inimitable Sobti's uninhibited Punjabi voice, as happy to span registers as it was to break the taboos of respectability. However, beyond the initial scandal, there is an impressive body of texts. I am thinking, in particular, of *Zindaginama* (1979), *Dil-o-Danish* (1993) and *Daar se Bichhuri* (2000).

The early disenchantment that set in as soon as the immediate violence of Partition had abated, made the pull of realism irresistible—and has produced an impressive and diverse body of texts. They give voice not only to the sadness of the centuries—the accumulated pain of poverty, caste and gender injustice—but, in contrast to Premchand, who died 10 years before Independence, they bring something more: a sense of betrayal of the promises of development and democracy. It is fascinating to see the way in which the deepening of democracy, and the disenchantment with the workings of the nominally 'democratic' state, have happened more or less in tandem.

The great danger here is of sounding like excerpts from newspapers, but this is deflected by various literary devices. The most flamboyant example, perhaps, is that of Phanishwar Nath Renu. Premchand's novels are rendered in a somewhat neutral, unaccented tone, divested of local and regional colour. What makes Renu unique is the unabashed adoption of the folk speech of his part of north Bihar, of Purnea. The resultant effect is hypnotic—as the persistent popularity of *Maila Aanchal* (1954) and the somewhat more extreme *Parti Parikatha* (1957) testify. This regional colour was sought to be dismissed in the early years, as *aanchalikta*, mere regionalism. But, as the subsequent development of the Hindi novel shows, the cultivation of local voices and accents has, in fact, become the preferred route for escaping from the narrative tedium produced by grimly persistent social realities. Shivprasad Singh's painstakingly rendered village of Karaita, in *Alag Alag Vaitarni* (1967), is a worthy example of the realist novel of betrayal. In Shrilal Shukla's *Raga Darbari* (1968), the pervasive irony of the narrative voice has transmuted the sense of betrayal into something like mockery: *vikaas* as farce.